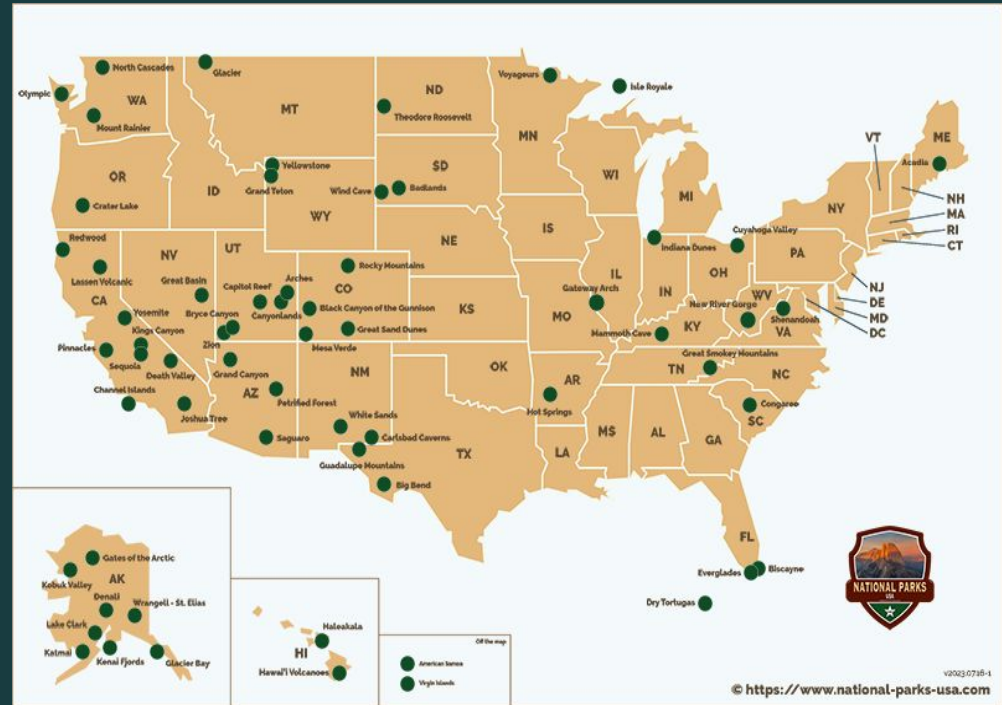


How has media impacted the National park attendance?

In this case study, we will be exploring the link between the rise of social media and the surge in National Park visitors, how can we see the trends and declines and make them work for us.



Timeline and key milestones

1

1998-2007 (the analog era)
growth of National parks

2

2010-2015 (Social media
Surge)

3

2020-2025 the steepest
declines to highest peaks
reached.

The Analog era (1998-2007)

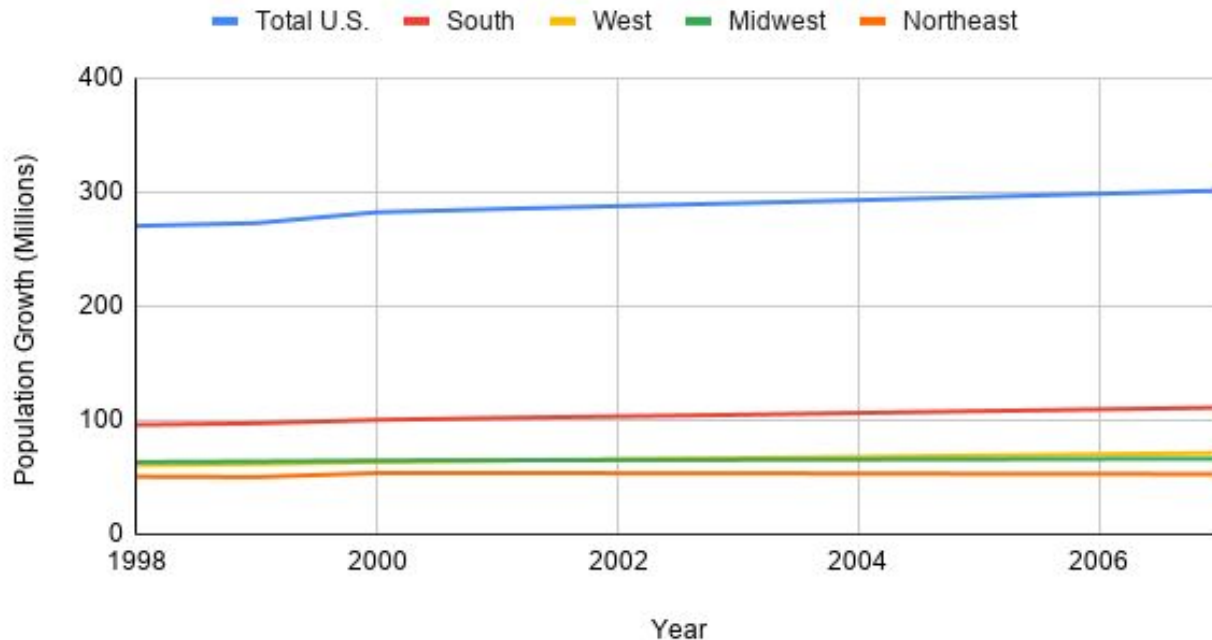
During the analog era visitation was driven by high-friction tourism but limited due by: Gatekeepers

- Paper Maps
- Disposable film cameras
- Payphones
- Travel agents
- Guidebooks/NPS mailers(7-10 day gap)

It not only took time but commitment to no real idea of what the place they are going to really looks like.

Travel required significant time, anywhere from 3-6 weeks making it more time consuming and tedious rather than a luxury. At the same time, the U.S. population continued to grow steadily, increasing by approximately 11.4%, this was due to National parks not capturing the domestic market due to high friction tourism.

United States population growth 1998-2007



Population Growth by percentage:

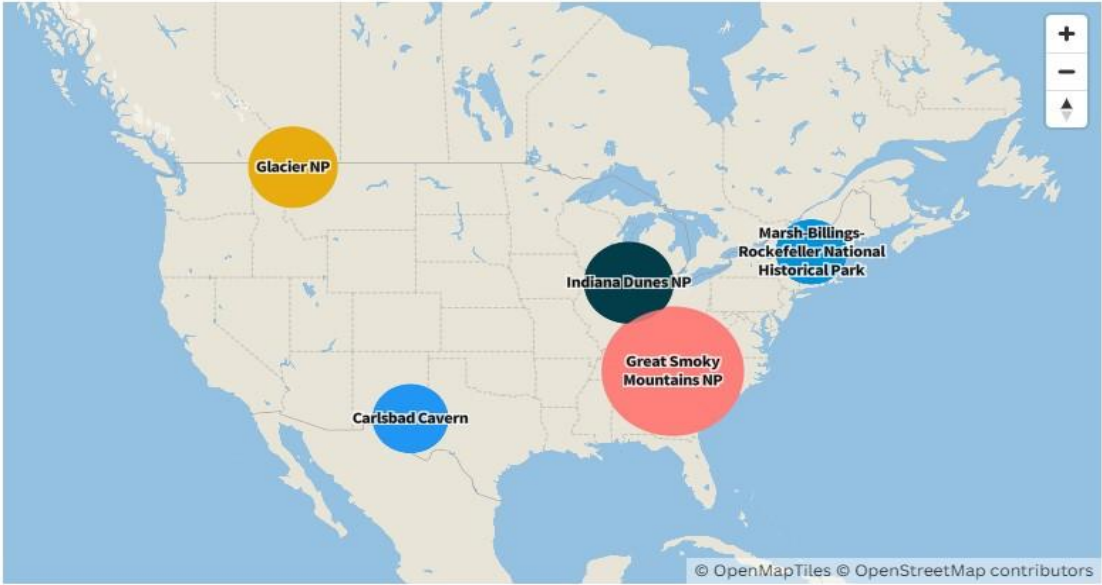
1. West: 17.85%
2. South: 15.75%
3. Midwest: 4.58%
4. North East: 4.36%
5. U.S. Total: 11.47%

But beyond the geography and population rates it comes down to the way people travel, the visitation patterns. This map represents the regional locations of the national parks, we can see that the south was still the top performing region. To understand why, we must take a look at the time period. During the analog era travel took time, money and commitment which meant people were not going to visit far off and remote destinations. This lead to more and more travelers that were look for easily accessible locations or along common travel routes. The south fit the description, it functions as a pass through region with major commuter pathways. Due to this parks in the south saw more and more visitation that other regions,leading to higher vistatation rates

Feature	The West (e.g., Zion, Yosemite)	The South (e.g., Smokies, Everglades)
Seasonality	Short (Summer Peak)	Year-Round (Warm Winters)
Entry Fee	Usually \$35+	Often \$0
Accessibility	Remote / Requires Flying	Highway Adjacent

"U.S. National Park Attendance Trends (1998–2007)

Annual Recreation Visitations



Source: [Google Sheet of all the data collected](#), IRMA Portal, [Where data was found](#)

Dormancy and the Surge

Attendance at national parks (2010–2015) wasn't just stalling it was dwindling. Why was such a big drop in attendance occurring? Due to national parks getting caught in issues that pertained to the people.

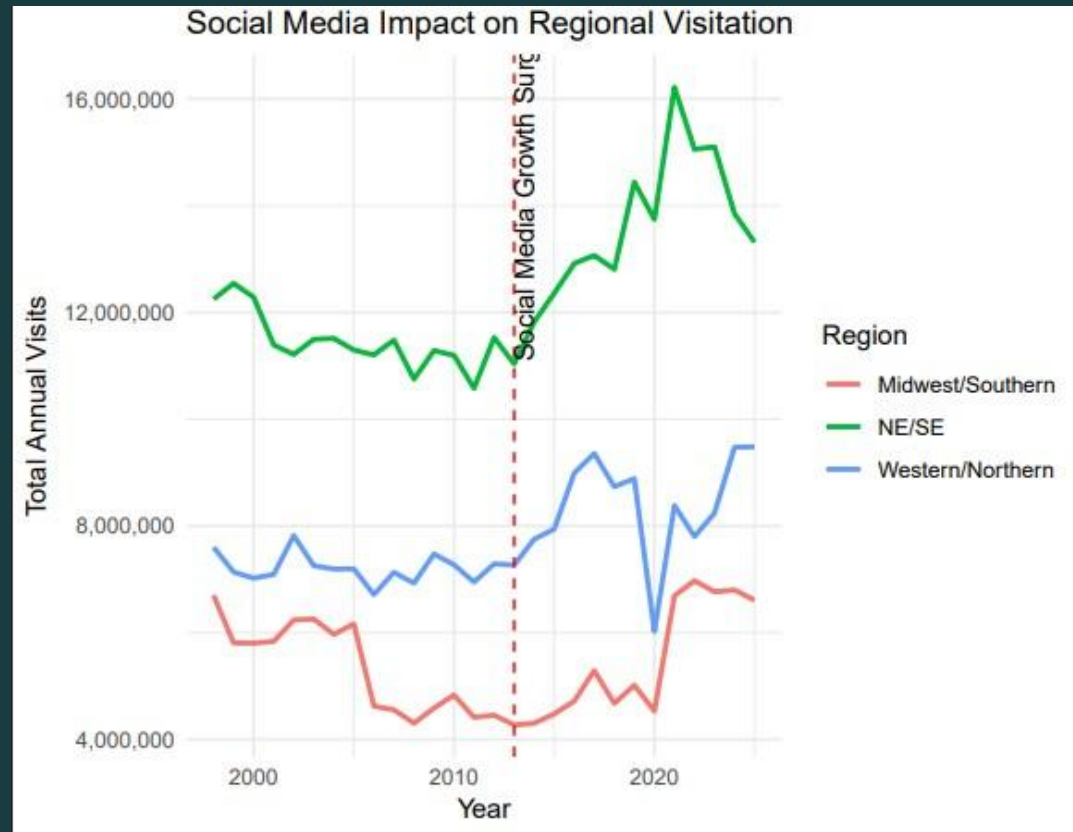
The Great recession

The 911 terrorist attacks

Too much demand not enough supply

Rapid advancement in technology

However, in the mid-2010s there was a complete reversal of fortune, there was 16–22% surge in visitation. This was larger than any attendance surge The National Park Service had ever had on record. "Visitation to National Parks in the United States increased by more than 25% since 2010, rising from roughly 70 to 90 million annual visitors."



Continuation of the surge

Unlike other Government agencies, National parks they depend on the people and during a time where the visual incentive was not high, people had to wait and see their destinations. They began using [instagram](#), [X](#), and the [Find Your Park](#) campaign. The result was a surge in visitation by 20–30% that broke all previous historical records by 2017. They even went as far as to create the [NPS centennial\(2016\)](#) this was the point where National parks acknowledged the digital shift and started using it. Unfortunately the success of the parks brought a new problem. Over tourism became so large there were new implementations for the growth of the National Parks,

- Timed entry reservations
- A new form –Digital Friction

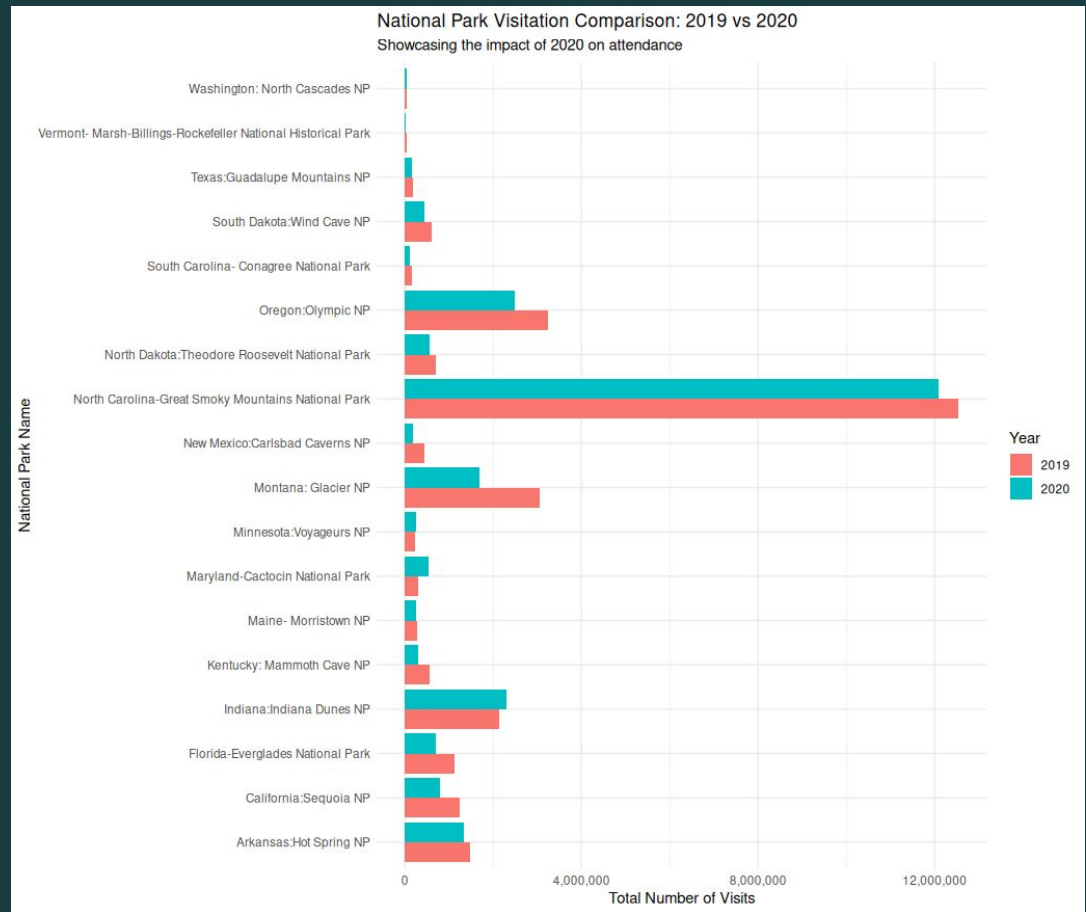
Feature	The Analog Dwindle (1998)	The Social Surge (2025)
Discovery	High Friction (Active Research)	Low Friction (Passive Consumption)
Information	official Brochures (Lag)	Peer-to-Peer Geotags (Real-Time)
Planning Time	Weeks	Seconds
Audience	Legacy Travelers	Inclusive / Diverse Travelers

↑ psychological "Logistical Risk" due to everything it takes to take a trip.

↑ Fomo induced due to more and more social peer to peer sharing.

The 2020 Stagnation

Sadly, the upward trend did not hold for National parks across the United States. In 2020 the saw The Great lockdown, this caused a sudden halt to all the momentum of the visitation at all national parks. Total visitation dropped from **327 million (2019)** to **237 million (2020)**—a staggering loss of nearly **90 million visitors** in a single year. In one year NPS saw how 20 years of progress was halted and rest to the analog era level of foot traffic. While physical visitation stopped the digital FOMO did not, it created a new surge in visitation after one year of pent up Demand.



- Contrast the **11.4% Population Growth** against the **0% Net Visitation Growth**.

The “Content Creator Responsibility” Era (2021–2023)

Unfortunately due to National parks attendance peaking again and over tourism after the 2020 pandemic there was a sense of “digital FOMO”. While higher attendance brought more attention and support to public lands, it also introduced new challenges there was a shift from Find Your Park to Leave No Trace, emphasizing commitments and exposures associated with park visitation, warnings against leaving designated trails, approaching wildlife, and littering or vandalizing any and all natural areas. This worked and many people incorporated it as part of their travel journeys.

The 'Hidden Gem' Pivot: larger parks began to reach capacity but, digital discovery shifted crowds to smaller, remote National Parks. This removed the mitigated pressure on major parks but created new challenges for smaller visitation parks to be able to handle high density traffic.

Feature	The Initial Surge (2015-2017)	The Managed Surge (2021-2025)
NPS Goal	"Find Your Park" (Awareness)	"Plan Like a Ranger" (Management)
Social Content	High-Quality Hero Shots	Tips for Reservations & Safety
Success Metric	Raw Attendance Volume	Visitor Distribution & Sustainability

To conclude:

Based on the

- analog era,

High travel friction and poor gatekeepers lead to stagnation

- the social surge,

How modern technology surpassed all previous growth

- the 2020 stagnation

Showed how national parks are required infrastructure for mental health.

- Content creator era

How modern incorporation of technology managed to help parks keep people safer/more aware.

It is concluded that national parks must move from marketing to management, The data shows that we have successfully solved the problem of 'Discovery.' The challenge for the next decade is 'Sustainability'—ensuring that the digital surge doesn't outpace the physical land.

Active digital management:
Partner with creators to disperse visitation for all parks to be able to function without overcrowding. Use the tool that caused the issue to redirect and help bridge the gaps.

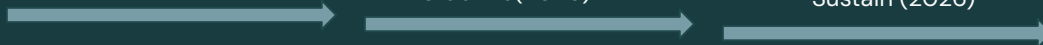
Close the analog gap:
Implementation of digital tools can help redirect issues commonly had in the analog era, parking availability, trail congestion, and even weather to allow all visitors to see how to travel safely and reduce the “logistical risk”.

Viability / Tenable:
Continue the usage of \$0-low entry fee prices for larger national parks while using demand-Based Pricing or reservations for smaller less equipped parks.

Discover (2015)

Stabilize(2020)

Sustain (2026)



Sources:

Primary attendance data: National Park Service (NPS) – Social Science Program

- National Park Service. (Year). Annual Visitation Summary Reports (1904 – Last Calendar Year). U.S. Department of the Interior.

U.S. Population & Regional Growth Data: U.S. Census Bureau – Historical Population Estimates

- U.S. Census Bureau. (2026). Historical Population Estimates by Region and State. U.S. Department of Commerce.

The "Social Media Surge" & Centennial Reports: NPS Centennial Report & "Find Your Park" Impact Study

- National Park Service. (2017). The Centennial Report: A Summary of 2016 Operations and Outreach. U.S. Department of the Interior.

The 2020 "Great Disruption" Data: NPS 2020 Visitation Abstract

- *National Park Service. (2021). National Park Service Releases 2020 Visitation Statistics. U.S. Department of the Interior.*

Open Data Portal: Data.gov - National Park Service Catalog

- <https://www.google.com/search?q=https://catalog.data.gov/dataset/national-park-service-visitor-use-statistics-79774>

"Data for this case study was aggregated from the National Park Service IRMA Portal (1998–2025) and cross-referenced with U.S. Census Bureau regional population growth estimates. All percentage calculations for 'Relative Market Share' were performed using official government year-end abstracts."

Links to data:

1. Posit
2. Flourish
3. Data analysis and mapping